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CENTERPIECE

One seedling at a time: Nonprofit gives away native plants, empowers youth

Ilana Williams iwilliams@somdnews.com
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Jeremy Tidd, owner and founder of Bona Terra, is engaged with the community by partnering with Nurture N: seedling giveaways to organizations and people.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

Esther Bonney turned her grief into growth by starting a nonprofit that aims to spread native plants.

Nurture Natives, a youth-led nonprofit organization, empowers young people through native biodiversity, restoration and education.

About a year and a half after losing her older brother to suicide, Bonney, a La Plata resident and founder of Nurture Natives, joined 4-H with the Charles County Pollinator Masters Club to study and dive into being outside with pollinators and native plants.

“I felt pretty lost,” Bonney said. “Then 4-H came into my life ... and I joined it not knowing that it would be such a beam of support.”

After attending the National 4-H Youth Summit on Agriscience, members were encouraged to design a project that would solve an agricultural issue, Bonney said. One of the issues that came up during conversations with farmers in Southern Maryland was invasive plant species.

Nurture Natives was created to address this agricultural issue and the broader environmental issue of invasive species.

These sustainable efforts helped the National 4-H Council select her as one of the 2026 4-H Youth in Action Award winners. Nurture Natives has planted 2.4 million native seeds, distributed 70,000 seedlings and engaged more than 10,000 young people to help protect native plants and pollinators, according to a release from 4-H.

“Pollination is what keeps our world functioning,” Bonney said. “Pollination is so key to both our agriculture and our environmental systems.”

Jeremy Tidd, owner and founder of Bona Terra, looked for ways to give back to the community and get more engagement about his native plant nursery when he decided to start giving seedlings away for free as part of a grant application, he said. Bona Terra grows 30 native plant species and is working to give away one million seedlings a year.

“There’s no shortage of seeds in the world,” Tidd said.

Bona Terra became involved with Nurture Native’s mission when Bonney called local nurseries to put pamphlets on display racks, Tidd said. Bona Terra invited Nurture Natives to the nursery.

“They saw that I was giving away seedlings and they wanted to volunteer,” Tidd said.

Bona Terra and Nurture Natives partnered to decide how to run seedling giveaway events and what training sessions to offer, Tidd said. They had their first training in March.

“Every time the world changes it’s because we’ve taught the next generation,” Tidd said. “Young adults ... were taught ... that we had to do something about it and now it’s just accepted, common knowledge.”

Nurture Natives is at the intersection of environmental stewardship and youth mental health, Bonney said. The organization is meant to help young people find meaning through environmental action who feel disconnected from nature or who feel powerless when hearing about the biodiversity crises.

“You might notice a lot of people who have a passion for gardening are older,” Bonney said. “A discussion that has been pretty consistent ... has been how do we bridge this gap?”

Bonney is a freshman at the University of Maryland, College Park and hopes to continue to grow Nurture Natives as a fellow with the university's Do Good Institute, where she will work on expanding the nonprofit's initiatives, she said.

"The coolest thing about the seedlings is it has made people brave," Tidd said. "This is a learning opportunity. Plants are amazing and have so much to teach us."